

Keith Hume Fraser Reserve Redevelopment

Keith Hume Fraser Reserve Redevelopment

95 Swansea Rd, Montrose — Project Summary & Proposal

Prepared for Yarra Ranges Council and Montrose Cricket Club — master plan rev 9.27

The proposal in brief

Keith Hume Fraser Reserve is an 11.95 ha reserve carrying two tired, poorly drained football pitches laid out in a way that wastes the ground available. This proposal redevelops the playing precinct into **four football pitches and two full-size community cricket grounds** on the same footprint, served by a new central pavilion, without touching the bushland that gives the reserve its character.

The layout places all four pitches on a single 310° alignment on the Swansea Rd side of the watercourse, in two paired precincts: the south ground (Pitch 1 at 88 × 60 m and Pitch 2 at 105 × 68 m) and the north ground (Pitch 3 at 100 × 68 m and Pitch 4 at 75 × 60 m). Between each pair sits a concrete cricket wicket with glued carpet, protected through winter by mobile technical-area shelters that roll over the wicket for the football season. Each pair is enclosed by a single fenced, laser-flat grass field, so that in summer each precinct converts to one continuous cricket ground: **C1 at a 110 m boundary and C2 at 100 m — genuine senior community sizes, fixed in the design.**

A new pavilion sits between Pitches 2 and 3 on a podium about 3 m above playing level — a 70 × 25 m enclosed building containing six player change rooms, two referee rooms, a first-aid room doubling as the uniform shop, and a canteen with serving windows to both Pitch 2 and Pitch 3 plus an internal window to the main club room. At its northern end the structure carries a **20 × 20 m elevated open deck for outdoor table viewing across Pitches 2 and 3**, and above the building a smaller rooftop viewing area sights **all four pitches** — the direct Montrose expression of Aspendale's celebrated elevated viewing deck. Every part of the plan is dimensioned in MGA55 coordinates and has been checked against pitch run-off standards, cricket boundary-buffer guidance, waterway offsets, and the parcel boundary.

The precedent: Aspendale Gardens Reserve

This is not a speculative concept — it is the model the City of Kingston has already delivered at

Aspendale Gardens, and the parallel is close to exact. That project produced a makeover of four football pitches and two cricket ovals plus training nets and twelve modern lighting poles, anchored by a contemporary single-storey pavilion housing four changerooms with amenities, a large kitchen and bar, a generous multi-purpose social space, and referee and first-aid rooms. Notably for our site, Aspendale's flood-level constraint was answered by raising the building onto an elevated amphitheatre-style platform with viewing across all pitches — precisely the role of our 3 m pavilion podium beside the Montrose drain. Aspendale was also delivered in stages — the sporting fields and car parking first, the pavilion second — and this proposal adopts the same discipline across three stages: **Stage 1** redevelops the lower oval into Pitches 3 and 4 with their cricket wicket and north-ground lighting, while the existing club rooms keep operating; **Stage 2** builds the new pavilion on its podium between the grounds; **Stage 3** removes the old rooms, builds Pitches 1 and 2 with the south cricket ground, and delivers the new ~220-space car park off the tennis-club entrance. Montrose can point to Aspendale as proof that a council-delivered project of exactly this shape works, is fundable in stages, and is loved by its clubs.

Reference: <https://shape.com.au/projects/aspendale-gardens-reserve-pavilion-city-of-kingston/>

Delivery and funding — how Aspendale got built

The numbers behind the precedent are as persuasive as the design. Kingston delivered the full Aspendale Gardens redevelopment in partnership with the Victorian Government, which contributed \$4.5 million alongside council's \$4.6 million — close to a 50/50 split on a roughly \$9.1 million ground transformation. The Stage 2 pavilion was a \$3.6 million project, again jointly funded by the state and council. The same state programs that funded Aspendale exist for Yarra Ranges: this proposal is not asking council to carry the project alone, it is asking council to sponsor a proven, co-funded model.

Delivery method matters as much as money on a constrained residential frontage. The Aspendale pavilion was built as a modular design-and-construct — fabricated off-site and craned into place — cutting construction noise for neighbours and keeping disruption to the operating clubs to a minimum. Given Swansea Rd's residential outlook and the intent that sport continues through both stages, this proposal adopts the same modular approach for the KHFR pavilion from the outset.

Kingston's advocacy case also travels directly to Montrose: purpose-built female-friendly change facilities for the fastest-growing segment of community sport (the six player change rooms proposed here serve exactly that demand), all-abilities inclusion through accessible amenities and hearing augmentation, and a consultation model in which a steering group of the residents association and the clubs shaped the design principles before a design brief was written. Their new carpark even double-serves the local primary school at drop-off — the same shared-use thinking proposed here for the tennis-entrance car park.

What Montrose Cricket Club gets

Two proper grounds instead of compromised ones: a 110 m boundary on the south ground and

100 m on the north, both protected in the design — the football geometry was made to fit around the cricket, not the other way round. The wickets are concrete with carpet, sited between the football pitches so neither code damages the other, and covered by the mobile shelters through winter. The grounds are continuous flat grass inside their fences with no internal obstructions. In a small number of fence sections the rope-to-fence gap runs under the guideline 2.74 m (tightest at the south ground's road-side taper and the north ground's corner cut); the plan documents these runs and the standard fixes — removable fence panels for the cricket season, or the usual local rule scoring ball-to-fence as a boundary — and the north-ground pinch is expected to relax once the channel survey confirms the arm's position.

Pitch lighting

The redevelopment includes new sports lighting across all four pitches, specified by role: the two main pitches (Pitch 2 and Pitch 3) aim for a **200 lux** average — the level required for senior club competition at night — while the two outer pitches (Pitch 1 and Pitch 4) aim for **100 lux**, the recognised standard for match practice and junior competition. This mirrors the tiered approach at Aspendale Gardens, where twelve modern lighting poles service the four-pitch layout with a 100 lux minimum across AFL (Australian football) and football requirements, and it concentrates the energy and capital cost where night competition will actually be played. Pole positions will be developed with the levels model so that no pole conflicts with the cricket outfields, the fence lines, or the watercourse offsets, and lighting spill toward the Swansea Rd dwellings and the northern bushland will be a design criterion from the first layout.

Cricket wicket orientation — assessed for how this reserve is actually used

Wicket orientation was checked against the published guidance rather than assumed. Cricket Australia's playing-field guidance calls for an approximately north–south wicket, within a window from 45° east of north to 35° west of north and an optimum of 10–15° east of north; the shared-ground geometry here fixes the wickets on the precinct's 310° bearing, about 15° outside that window. Stated plainly, neither this layout nor the existing ground complies with the letter of the guidance — the existing wickets run on roughly a 50° axis, which also sits at or just beyond the window's eastern edge. What matters is which non-compliance is safer, and a site-specific solar assessment for Melbourne answers that clearly in favour of the new alignment for the way this reserve is actually used.

Play at Keith Hume Fraser Reserve is concentrated in the afternoon and early evening: junior fixtures run on Friday nights, and men's and women's games start at 1pm and continue to around 7pm. The operative hazard is therefore the low western sun late in the day, which in the cricket season sits at azimuth ~240–255°. On the existing ~50° axis, the batter at the north-eastern end faces 230° — within 10–25° of the setting sun's direct line, receiving the ball essentially out of the glare through the final session. This is the precise failure mode that halted an international at Napier's McLean Park, where a non-standard wicket alignment put the setting sun in the batters' eyes and play was suspended on safety grounds. On the proposed 310° axis the evening sun sits

55–70° off both batters’ sight lines — well outside the glare cone — transferring the residual nuisance to square fielders on the south-western side, a trade any ground would take, and one further softened here because the low western sun path crosses the retained treed drain corridor rather than an open horizon. Friday-night junior fixtures are unaffected by sun altogether. In short: the new orientation is a measurable safety improvement over the existing ground for this reserve’s actual playing pattern, and the analysis is offered up-front rather than left for review to find.

Why this is an easy approval for Council

The scheme doubles the reserve’s playing capacity while shrinking its impact. The steep north corner remains untouched bushland reserve. Every goal-line fence sits at the 4 m minimum specifically to pull the fenced footprint off the treed Swansea Rd frontage — roughly 860 m² less clearing than earlier iterations of this same plan. Both existing Swansea Rd entrances with their turning lanes are retained as-is. The watercourse is barely touched (detailed below), existing community infrastructure like the reverse vending machine stays where it is, and the whole project can be delivered in two stages that keep sport running throughout.

Detail 1 — The old tennis club entrance, driveway and a ~220-space car park

The former Montrose Terrace tennis club entrance enters the reserve at its south corner directly off Swansea Rd, and the proposal builds the site’s main car park around it — sized at approximately **6,200 m² for about 220 car spaces** (at the standard planning rate of 28 m² per space including aisles, AS 2890), comfortably above the 120–180 spaces a four-pitch, two-oval venue typically requires at peak, with room held in reserve to the north if a traffic assessment ever asks for more.

The arrangement deliberately spends nothing on new road or drainage infrastructure. Vehicle access reuses the **existing formed crossover and its established turning-lane treatments** on Swansea Rd — no new intersection, no new turn-lane works, and no additional assessment burden beyond the existing entrance’s capacity. Where the access driveway crosses the lower Montrose drain just inside the entrance, it does so at the **existing culvert crossing**, retained in place — the only work anticipated there is a condition and capacity check on the existing structure, which folds neatly into the Melbourne Water conversation already required for the channel deviation upstream. From the culvert, only about **75 m of new driveway** is needed to reach the car park, because the parking has been drawn as far south on the old tennis terrace as the site constraints allow.

The car park’s position also answers the nearest neighbour before they ask: it stands roughly **12 m off the western boundary** adjoining the residential property, with that strip retained as vegetation, and its whole footprint sits on the already-disturbed former tennis ground rather than in native vegetation. Match-day traffic therefore enters at the corner of the site, parks within 100

m of the gate, and never crosses the pedestrian routes between the pitches — while the two existing Swansea Rd entrances with their turning lanes continue serving the central and pavilion areas unchanged, giving the reserve three functioning access points without a single new road connection.

Detail 2 — The watercourse is changed as little as possible

The reserve's defining constraint is the water path through its middle, and the design's answer is restraint. The **main watercourse — the west branch and the lower leg to the southern exit — is not moved at all**. The lower Montrose drain along the south-west, whose true position was field-verified during design (it runs naturally further west than older mapping suggested), is likewise **retained exactly on its existing course** — the verification removed any need to touch it. The only physical channel work in the entire scheme is a single **~105 m realignment of the upper Montrose drain reach**, sweeping it around the north corners of Pitch 2 at a constant 5 m clear of the pitch. It is drawn as a naturalised channel — gentle meanders, no straight runs, no sharp bends — replacing what is today an awkward right-angle jog, so the works arguably leave the channel in better form than they find it. This is the one item requiring Melbourne Water consent, and it is deliberately modest: same function, same connectivity, ~105 m of improved channel. The north-east arm is not altered as a channel at all; the plan shows it at its design position pending a confirming survey, and the fences and pitches hold the standard 5 m offset from it throughout.

Detail 3 — The reverse vending machine stays where it is

The reverse vending machine in the central car park off Swansea Rd is retained **in its current position, untouched**. The playing precincts, fences, pavilion podium and channel works were all laid out around it as a fixed point — its location is carried in the coordinate model alongside the pitches and fences, and no element of the plan encroaches on it or its servicing access from the central car park. Council's container-deposit infrastructure therefore continues operating through both construction stages without relocation cost or service interruption — a small point, but one that signals the design philosophy of the whole scheme: keep everything that works, and spend the project's budget only on what doesn't.

Staged delivery and indicative costs

The Aspendale benchmark makes an honest first-pass cost frame possible before any quantity surveying: Kingston's full ground transformation ran to roughly \$9.1 million (\$4.6M council, \$4.5M Victorian Government), of which the 1,064 m² pavilion was \$3.6 million. Scaling those rates to the Montrose scope, and stating plainly that these are Aspendale-benchmarked planning figures — pre-survey, pre-QS, and subject to construction escalation since that project — the staging breaks down approximately as follows.

Stage	Scope	Indicative cost (Aspendale-benchmarked)
1	Pitches 3 & 4, north cricket ground (C2), wicket, fencing, drainage platform, north lighting (200/100 lux)	\$2.5M – \$3.0M
2	Pavilion on 3 m podium: 70 × 25 m enclosed + 20 × 20 m elevated viewing deck + rooftop viewing area (modular design-and-construct)	\$3.5M – \$6.5M (see note)
3	Pitches 1 & 2, south cricket ground (C1), wicket, fencing, south lighting, ~220-space car park, 75 m driveway, drain deviation	\$3.0M – \$3.5M
Indicative total		\$9M – \$13M

The Stage 2 band deserves a straight explanation: even at 70 × 25 m the enclosed building (~1,750 m²) is well above the floor area of Aspendale’s \$3.6M, 1,064 m² pavilion, and at Aspendale’s ~\$3,400/m² rate the enclosed works alone approach \$6M. The recomposition of the northern 20 m into an open elevated deck is the design’s own value-management move — roofless deck structure prices at a fraction of enclosed, serviced floor area, trimming several hundred thousand dollars from the brief while adding the venue’s best social asset: outdoor table viewing across both main pitches, with the rooftop area above sighting all four. Settling the final envelope belongs to the Stage 2 design phase, informed by what state co-funding is available. On the funding side, the Aspendale split is the model: with a comparable state partnership, council’s share of even the full program lands in the \$5–7M range spread across three budget years, each stage independently useful if later stages are deferred.

Status and next steps

The geometry is complete and internally verified at rev 9.27 (drawing set KHFR rev 9-27: master plan, aerial overlay, and MGA55 coordinate schedule): every dimension, fence vertex, boundary circle and channel line is issued as MGA55 coordinates ready for a surveyor. Three items close out the design: a field survey of the north-east arm’s bank position (which gates Pitch 3/4 lengths and improves the C2 fence margins), the Vicmap contour data for the levels and earthworks model of the two ground platforms and pavilion podium, and a Melbourne Water pre-application conversation on the ~105 m drain deviation. Ball-stop treatment along the Swansea Rd frontage is anticipated as a likely council condition and is accommodated by the fence design.